Historical source

Encyclopaedia Britannica scan, source row 247. Parse 3.5 extracted the text. Super 3.5 VL corrected it from an enlarged crop of each block. It can still contain recognition errors. Page headers, footers, and page numbers are removed.

Untitled continuation (E0006)

Continues an entry from an earlier page.

E T N [8] E T N

Eta.

(our author fays) it would be difficult to make people, who have never engaged in such enterprises, comprehend all the obstacles they had to encounter. This cone (the little mountain mentioned by Sir William Hamilton) is composed of ashes, fand, and pozzolano, thrown up at different times by the volcano. The materials are fo loose, that the adventurous traveller finks about mid-leg at every step, and is in constant terror of being fwallowed up. At last, when the summit is reached, the sulphureous exhalations, which are continually emitted from the pores of the mountain, threaten suffocation, and irritate the faces and lungs in such a manner as to produce a very troublesome and incessant cough. The looseness of the foil, which gives way under the feet, obliges the traveller, every now and then, to throw himself flat on his belly, that fo he may be in less danger of sinking. In this posture our author viewed the wide unfathomable gulph in the middle of the crater; but could discover nothing except a cloud of smoke, which iffued from a number of small apertures scattered all around, and accompanied with a kind of noie. Another and more dreadful found, however, iffues from the bowels of the volcano, and which, according to our author, "frikes the heart with terror, fo that all the strength of reason is necessary to prevent the observer from flying with precipi-tation from such a dreadful place." Several travellers who had vifited this cone before him, were fo terrified by the dreadful founds, that they fled with the utmost haste till they arrived at the foot of the mountain.

Our author compares these founds to a discharge of cannon in the wide abyss; the noise of which is rebellowed throughout all the caverns, and produces a found perhaps the most alarming that can be imagined; and during the short space in which he listened, several of these discharges were heard to follow one another almost uninterruptedly.

This dreadful noise, our author, with very great probability, supposes to be occasioned by the explosions of the internal fire, or, as he calls it, the focus of the volcano; which, striking against the sides of the immense caverns, the sounds produced are re-echoed through their cavities, and probably multiplied in an extraordinary manner; so that what would be only a flight explosion in the open air, occasions a sound more tremendous than the loudest thunder. To such as are convinced of this, and have sufficient courage to recur the first impressions which these sounds must unavoidably occasion, they will in a short time not only appear exceedingly sublime, but, by their variety, even formidable what agreeable. "They enable us (says our author) to form some conception of the space through which they must pass before they reach the ear, and of the vast extent and width of the hollows of the mountain."

Having for some time contemplated this awful spectacle, our author wished to measure the crater by walking round it; but found this impracticable. On the north side the surface is hard and smooth, the ashes having been so far dissolved by the moisture deposited by the fume as to cement into one uniform mass. This is sometimes dissolved even into a fluid state, in such a manner as to run down the sides of the cone; so that after several attempts, he was at last obliged to abandon his design.

Fig. 2. exhibits a view of the crater of Etna taken

Fig. 2. exhibits a view of the crater of Etna taken No 121.

on the brink of the craft side. The fore-ground (a a) of the figure is one division of the crater. Beyond it are two eminences b and c, higher than that on which some human figures are reprefented. All the three form a triangle nearly equilateral; but, when viewed from any considerable distance, only two of them can be seen; for which reason the Sicilians have termed the mountain bicorne, or double-horned.

The smoke, as represented in the figure, issues from all quarters, either from chinks or holes scattered over the whole crater. But the situation of the principal mouth is in the midst of the three eminences. Its diameter, when our author visited this mountain, was only about 60 feet, and so filled with smoke that no thing remarkable could be discovered. From the height of the rock situated on the left side of the print, and on which the human figures are represented, all the way to the rock s on the right, the distance is no more than 900 feet. Our author offered that the cone is not exactly in the middle of the plain, but is situated more towards the north than the south. He did not attempt to cross the central valley, on account of the looseness of the ground, and that there was no object

apparently worthy of the risk he must run in so doing. At the nearest view he took, it was only observed that there was snow lying in several parts of it, though the heat which otherwise prevailed seemed to be very intense.

The smoke which issues from the crater of Etna is generally carried in a direction from south to north; and, as it brings along with it a considerable quantity of water, the latter, condensed by the cold winds, runs down the side of the mountain in plentiful streams, and often leaves pretty permanent marks of its course.

and often leaves pretty permanent marks of its course. In this manner he accounts for the great eruption of water in 1755, which he supposes to have been occasioned only by an unusual quantity of water falling into the burning focus of the mountain, there raised into steam, and afterwards condensed by the coldness of the atmosphere.

Like other travellers to mount Etna, this gentleman found the wind blowing from the fourth; and he is of opinion, that a fourthwind blows here more frequently than any other, as he did not observe any channels cut by the water on any other side than the north. He had several opportunities of making this observation, having frequently visited the top of Etna, and always paid attention to the crater. The fend on the call and west sides was always loose, while that on the north was compacted into a solid body. The three fummits were of a later date than the rest of the crater, having been probably thrown up by some eruption which had burst it asunder. The black spots on the fore-ground represent a number of hillocks about the size of mole-hills, from which a sulphureous vapour constantly issues, and by which the adjacent ground is tinged of an ochery colour. This vapour issues from the crevices with a kind of hollow whirling noise; which with the volcanic thunder, smoke, and noxious smell, render it very disagreeable to stay here even for a few moments.

The smoke is represented in the figure precisely as it did on the day that he ascended, which was very warm. But it does not always rise in this manner; for when the cold is very intense, it collects into a body, and thickens around the edge of the crater: on which occasions it is condensed into water, which diffuses itself around the edge of the crater, and mixing with the ashes

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